

Idiopathic Horner's Syndrome in Dogs

What is it?

Horner's syndrome is caused by damage to the nerves that control the eye and surrounding face muscles.

"**Idiopathic**" means no cause can be found even after testing. It looks alarming but **is usually not serious**.

Signs

- **Small pupil** in one eye
- **Droopy upper eyelid**
- **Sunken-looking eye**
- **Third eyelid** visible in the inner corner
- Sometimes redness or fewer tears

Why is it hard to find a cause?

The nerve pathway is long — from the brainstem, down the spinal cord into the chest, up the neck, through the middle ear and behind the eye. Damage anywhere along this path causes the same signs. Possible causes include middle/inner ear disease, neck or chest problems, and, in diabetic dogs, nerve damage (sometimes both eyes).

Diagnosis

- Complete neurological and eye exams

- Blood tests (including thyroid)
- Imaging — X-rays, MRI or CT
- Special eye drops may help locate the problem, but results can be inconsistent

If everything is normal, the diagnosis is **idiopathic Horner's syndrome**. **Golden Retrievers** appear to be predisposed.

Treatment and outlook

- Usually **no treatment is needed**
- Often **improves on its own within weeks to months**
- It is **not painful** or life-threatening and does not affect vision or quality of life

Monitoring

- Recheck visits to confirm improvement
- **Take photos** of the eyes to track changes
- Watch for **new signs** — head tilt, balance problems, facial drooping, ear discharge, voice change or illness. These suggest an underlying cause and need re-evaluation.